

## Z Calculus

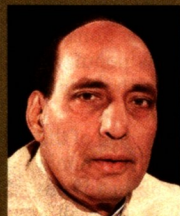
The security for many VIPs will be downgraded



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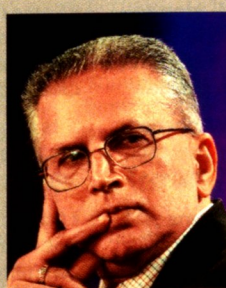
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vealed that most of those who have been provided security face no threat and do not need it at all or have been given a security level that is much higher than warranted. It has become more of a status symbol and at least one MP is known to have sought enhanced security cover upon receiving a crank text message.

Home Secretary G.K. Pillai admits that the system of VIP security, like any other long-standing system, has been abused over the years. "There is a growing feeling that VIPs are being provided security at the cost of citizens' security," he says. Though the review of individual security is still on—almost in its final stages now—some decisions have already been taken towards the rationalisation of the security structure. The ministry has decided to reduce one person each from various categories of security—X, Y, Z and Z-plus. It has already been implemented in Y category security. Previously, this category included 24x7 security with two

PSOs, a head constable and four constables posted at the residence.

Also, the ministry has decided that it will go strictly as per inputs given by the Intelligence Bureau (IB) regarding the threat level to an individual. Also, political considerations or affiliations will not be allowed to come into play. There are only a few who face a genuine threat and have been given security accordingly. These include BJP leaders L.K. Advani and Narendra Modi, former and present Jammu and Kashmir chief ministers Farooq Abdullah, Ghulam Nabi Azad and Omar Abdullah, and Assam Chief Minister Tarun Gogoi.



**“VIP security has been abused over the years. There is a feeling that VIPs are being provided security at the cost of citizens' safety.”**

G.K. PILLAI, Union Home Secretary

The ministry is also considering changing rules which enable former prime ministers and their families to continue to enjoy SPG security cover for a decade after they demit office. "There is no reason why somebody like Deve Gowda or I.K. Gujral should have enjoyed security cover after they ceased to be prime ministers. Even former PMs should be provided security on the basis of threat assessment," says a senior MHA official. The ministry is aware that it may not be that easy to make drastic changes in the security set-up at one go and that it is treading on a minefield that can make the whole lot of VIPs fret and fume. There was evidence of that on July 22 when Mulayam Singh Yadav and Lalu Prasad Yadav, among those whose security is likely to be downgraded, raised loud protests in Parliament. As of now Chidambaram seems determined.

Pillai admits it will be difficult to withdraw an individual's security altogether but a gradual scaling down will be done. Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati, for example, may lose her Z-plus with National Security Guard (NSG) status but will retain a lower level of Z-plus or Z category security. Former NSG chief J.K. Dutt, who had led NSG operations in Mumbai during the 26/11 terror attacks, has favoured entrusting all VIP protection duties to a new or unified agency that should develop special expertise for the job. He says that the new agency could be created at par with the CISF which guards airports, public sector units and installations.

The home minister has made a start. When Parliament assembles for its next session, many VIPs will be shorn of their elaborate and needless security cover. The high domed edifice will once again resemble the House of the People it was meant to be rather than the fortress it has come to be over the years. ■